PENGZHEN LI

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EDUCATION

University of Tennessee, Knoxville expected 2027
Ph.D. in Economics
Committee: James Lake (Chair), Georg Schaur, Matthew Van Essen, Timothy Fitzgerald

Shandong University, Jinan 2018
M.A. in Finance — thesis published in *Technological Forecasting and Social Change* (2019)

Tongji University, Shanghai 2015
B.A. in Economics

RESEARCH INTERESTS

International Trade, Trade Policy, Applied Econometrics, and Political Economy.

WORKING PAPERS

Measured Quality Falls Within the Firm: Market Access and Chinese Exports [Job Market Paper]. [paper]
Abstract: This paper links the 2002 removal of tariff uncertainty on Chinese exports to the United States to a decline in measured quality within continuing export relationships. Comparing a firm's US and non-US shipments of the same product, measured quality falls by about 6 percent among cells that ship in both periods in the three years before an overlapping quota removal, and by about 11 percent in the full sample over the whole window, which contains that removal. Restricting the sample to cells that ship in both periods retains 83 percent of the full-window estimate and yields a decline twice as large as the full-sample estimate in the three clean years. The price and quantity responses are not those of a markup cut on an unchanged good, and the decline is not the input-tariff upgrading of the same years, which varies only within firm and year and is absorbed by the design. We develop a model in which improved access can extend a seller's reach to buyers below a sorting boundary, who lower the return to appeal. Under stated conditions, appeal is capped and can fall. The continuing-cell price and quantity pattern is consistent with this mechanism but does not identify it against other sources of a demand-residual shift.

Trade Restrictiveness Indices with Discriminatory Tariffs with James Lake. *Presented at the Midwest Economic Theory and International Trade Meetings, Virginia Tech, 2025.* [paper]
Abstract: This paper extends the Trade Restrictiveness Index (TRI) to preferential tariffs. Using data for 2000–2020, a period of rapid expansion of Preferential Trade Agreements (PTAs), we compute 2,406 annual TRIs for 136 countries in an Armington model with large countries. Once terms-of-trade effects are taken into account, the global import-weighted TRI lies well below the average tariff, and the TRI for preferential tariffs declines faster than the TRI for MFN tariffs as the share of trade under PTAs grows. Across countries, average tariffs track the TRI poorly: the largest importers have TRIs far below their average tariffs, while many small economies have TRIs above them. Assuming that countries are small overstates the TRI, most of all for large importers.

Estimating Mean-Field Games with a Payoff Threshold: Candidates and Party Lists in Brazil with Matt Van Essen and Luiz Lima. *2024 J. Fred and Wilma Holly Award (best second-year paper).* [paper]

Abstract: Estimating a discrete-choice game of incomplete information means evaluating the joint action profile, which forecloses the settings such games describe: a Brazilian municipality fielding fifty-five council candidates across five lists has far too many action profiles to enumerate. We change the equilibrium concept rather than the algorithm. Anonymity makes the fixed point one dimension per list and none per candidate, and a discontinuous winner rule turns existence into a regime-consistency problem over proposed clearing sets, which we show can have no solution. Because a threshold pays several alternatives at once, two can be compared inside one market, and three log-odds contrasts identify the parameters with no probability of abstention anywhere in the estimator. At municipal scale the likelihood attenuates the coefficient on the anticipated chance of a seat, because a list's share is counted from a few dozen candidates, and a split-sample instrument on an unbiased reciprocal of that share recovers nine-tenths of it in simulation. On 926,900 Brazilian council candidacies the corrected coefficient is positive for non-incumbents and for all candidates, for every one of thirty-two demographic types, and with and without a control for local party strength; its magnitude under that control is not stable. Candidates with a university degree respond more to the chance of a seat than candidates without one, a difference found among non-incumbents and not among incumbents.

PEER-REVIEWED PUBLICATIONS

"Spatial optimization of the sustainable aviation fuel supply chains from forest residues via fast pyrolysis/hydrotreatment considering feedstock ash content variability." **P. Li**, T. E. Yu, N. Labbé, N. Abdoulmoumine, M. Garcia-Perez, K. P. Hoyt, and B. C. English. *Biomass and Bioenergy*, 208 (2026), 108793.

"Assessing the impact of preprocessing and conversion technologies on the sustainable aviation fuel supply from forest residues in the Southeast USA." **P. Li**, T. E. Yu, C. Trejo-Pech, J. A. Larson, B. C. English, and D. N. Lanning. *Transportation Research Record*, 2678(9) (2024), 639–654.

"Beef price spread relationship with processing capacity utilization." C. Martinez, **P. Li**, C. N. Boyer, T. E. Yu, and J. G. Maples. *Journal of the Agricultural and Applied Economics Association*, 2(1) (2023), 133–145.

"Do green technology innovations contribute to carbon dioxide emission reduction? Empirical evidence from patent data." K. Du, **P. Li**, and Z. Yan. *Technological Forecasting and Social Change*, 146 (2019), 297–303.

PRESENTATIONS

Midwest Economic Theory and International Trade Meetings, Virginia Tech — Spring 2025
University of Tennessee, Economics Brown Bag Seminar Series — Spring 2024, Fall 2024
University of Tennessee, Applied Micro Group — Spring 2024, Fall 2024
Western Regional Science Association, Annual Meeting, Hawaii — 2023
Western Agricultural Economics Association, Annual Meeting, Santa Fe, NM — 2022
Southern Agricultural Economics Association, Annual Meeting, New Orleans, LA — 2022

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

University of Tennessee

Instructor

ECON 351: Monetary Economics — Spring 2025, Spring 2026
ECON 322: The Global Economy: Trade and Development — Summer 2025
ECON 313: Intermediate Macroeconomics — Summer 2026

Teaching Assistant

Ph.D. courses:

ECON 511: Microeconomic Theory	Fall 2023, Fall 2024, Fall 2025
ECON 512: Advanced Microeconomics	Spring 2024
ECON 581: Mathematical Methods in Economics	Summer 2024

Master's courses:

AREC 525: Agribusiness Operations Research Methods	Spring 2022, Spring 2023

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

University of Tennessee – Knoxville, TN 2021 – present
Graduate Research & Teaching Assistant. USDA NIFA and FAA ASCENT projects (2021–2023): mixed-integer supply-chain optimization (GAMS), IMPLAN/DEA siting analysis, and spatial data pipelines (ArcGIS, R, Python) for forest-residue sustainable aviation fuel; two publications and three working papers.

Shandong University – Jinan, China 2016 – 2018
Graduate Research Assistant. Panel-threshold and machine-learning analysis of green innovation and CO_2 emissions (published in *TFSC*, 2019).

HONORS AND AWARDS

Charles B. Garrison Award for Excellence in Teaching (best teaching), University of Tennessee	2026
Summer Graduate Assistantship, University of Tennessee	2025
J. Fred and Wilma Holly Award (best second-year paper), University of Tennessee	2024
J. Fred and Wilma Holly Fellowship, University of Tennessee	2023 – present
Graduate Assistantship, University of Tennessee	2021 – present
Academic Scholarship for Master's Students, Shandong University	2017
Freshman Scholarship, Shandong University	2016
Outstanding Rainbow Volunteer, Tongji University (tutoring pupils in Shanghai)	2013 – 2015
National Endeavor Scholarship, Tongji University	2014
Tongji Scholarship of Excellence, Third Prize, Tongji University	2014

SKILLS

Programming Languages: Stata, R, Python, SQL, GAMS, MATLAB, LaTeX, ArcGIS, IMPLAN.
Languages: Chinese (native), English (fluent).

REFERENCES

James Lake (Chair)
Associate Professor of Economics
Department of Economics
University of Tennessee
Email: jlake7@utk.edu

Georg Schaur
Leigh Burch III Economics Professor and Haslam Family Faculty Fellow
Department of Economics
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Matthew Van Essen
Lena M. and Clarence A. Garvin, Sr. Professor and Dr. Joe Johnson Faculty Fellow
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